

The Serial Killer

If it wasn't for Lalit Modi's immodesty, the IPL would be a matchwinner on and off the field

Only Lalit Modi could have done this with his chronic tendency of looking for trouble to run into. Even as his world comes tumbling down, every commercial indicator of the IPL is up. Viewership has risen from an average TRP of 4 last year to 4.5 this year, with the cumulative reach going up to 138 million for the first 53 matches from 121 million last year, and more viewers among 4 to 14-year-olds as well as women. Team franchisees are making at least 40 per cent higher revenue than last time, thanks to a hike in their share of the central revenue pool with new sources such as after-parties and the MRF blimp, as well as greater local revenue through team sponsorships and gate receipts. Sony, now called MSM, regardless of its trouble with the taxmen, is making a revenue of Rs 700 crore this year having raised ad rates to Rs 4-5 lakh per 10 seconds. Even Modi's *bête noire*, the income tax authorities, arrived at a preliminary figure of Rs 1,170 crore as BCCI's income from IPL-3.

Thanks to IPL-1, the BCCI made a profit of Rs 350 crore in 2008, which was more than its profit for all of 2007. Its profit for 2010 is expected to touch Rs 700 crore. It's no surprise then that the Board was willing to look the other



THE POPULARITY OF THE IPL IS EVIDENT FROM ITS HIGH TRPs

way while Modi oiled wheels and struck deals. As a spectator sport, after a somewhat lame Season 2, IPL-3 found itself firmly ensconced in the nation's evening embrace, driving down the viewership of the top five soaps on general entertainment channels in this period (just an example, Star Plus' *Yeh Rishta Kya Kehlata Hai* was 6.8 before IPL and 5.3 during the tournament). The tournament threw up shining new stars, on and off the field, from the dashing Murali Vijay to the affable Angad Bedi.

Not every deal Modi struck was profitable—for instance, though the IPL may have made Rs 330 crore for 10 years by selling theatrical rights to Entertainment Sports Direct, the revenue looks unlikely to match it.

But if it could speak to Modi, the cheeky scoreboard which revels in being rude (it said Good Knight to Kolkata Knight Riders as they exited the tournament) would say: Butter Fingers. He had it all only to drop it all.

by Kaveree Bamzai

IPL-3 MATCHES

	4.7	4.0	4.5
Average TVR (%) of last 53 matches			
Reach for last 53 matches (in millions)	100	121	138

Source: Television Audience Measurement

seems to be left, unless he still believes that as the patron saint of India's most celebrated national festival on television, he has the mandate to reign unchallenged.

His struggle, in the end, is all about power, which in India today is no longer defined by politics alone. Modi, who even in his worst moment is suited in pastel perfection, also tells us how the gentleman's game has become a hustler's passion—and how it brings politics, business and glitter to an unsavoury profit-sharing arrangement. Even the Government's commitment to the de-Modification of the IPL has a subtext of coalition compulsions. Modi is more vulnerable because his political protector has been forced to ditch him. So, a scalded, falling IPL chief has become the singular evil, and the suddenly awakened cricket cleansers hope his elimination will bring in redemption. That is false hope. The system that enabled Modi to play the highest lord of the game is still intact, and it is unlikely that the avenging masters of fair play will go for a total shake-up. The story doesn't end with the fall of Lalit Kumar Modi. He has made it murkier. ■